

- Adhere to established protocols - look for tried-and-true methods in your team or department that you can use.
- Label folders appropriately - label folders with the subject areas to which they pertain, not with the names of specific researchers or students. This minimises confusion in shared workspaces in the event of a staff member's departure and makes the file system easier to traverse for newcomers.
- Consistency is critical when designing a naming scheme for your folders. Once you've decided on a method, it's critical to keep to it. If possible, attempt to agree on a naming scheme for your research project from the start.
- Organize folders hierarchically - begin with a small number of broad-topic folders and then expand upon them with more specific ones.
- Separate ongoing and completed work - when your folders and files grow in size, it's a good idea to consider separating your older documents from those you're currently working on.
- Maintain a 'My Documents' folder for files that you are actively working on, and move files that you are no longer working on to a separate folder or location, such as a folder on your desktop, a specific archive folder, or an external hard drive, once a month or so.
- Backup - Ensure that your files are backed up, whether they are on your local disc or a network drive.
- Review records - evaluate materials on a regular basis or at the conclusion of a project to verify that no files are retained indefinitely. Make a note on your calendar to ensure you do not forget!

Naming files

At the outset of your project, establish a file name convention.

Useful file names are:

- Consistent
- Easily interpreted by you and your colleagues
- Easy to locate

It is advantageous if your department/project agrees on the following file name elements:

- Vocabulary – Select a standard vocabulary for file names to ensure that everyone speaks the same language.
- Punctuation – establish norms about the usage of punctuation symbols, capital letters, hyphens, and spaces.